Lesson Plan: Articles, the vs. no article

B2 (intermediate) | 18 adult ESL learners | University intensive English program | 120 minutes

Objectives

By the end of this lesson, learners will be able to:

- Tell apart *the* (specific reference) and the zero article (general categories and abstract nouns).
- Produce 6 to 8 sentences with the zero article for abstract nouns and general categories in a speaking activity.

Rationale

Articles are among the hardest areas of English grammar because languages treat definiteness differently. Many learners come from languages with no articles (for example Chinese and Russian) or with different article systems (for example Arabic). This leads to predictable overuse of *the* before abstract nouns (*the honesty*) and general categories (*the politicians*). Ionin, Ko and Wexler (2004) explain that many learners rely on specificity rather than definiteness. Folse (2016) recommends teaching grammar in focused, manageable chunks. This lesson isolates one B2 challenge: *the* for specific reference against the zero article for categories and concepts.

Materials

- Whiteboard or projector and slides
- Rule table (Appendix A, below)
- Articles Worksheet and answer key (separate PDF)
- Debate Cards (separate PDF)

Procedure

Stage	Time	What happens
Lead-in	15 min	Display five sentences with article errors: *I think the patience is a virtue. I don't like the spiders. The poverty is a huge issue. I bought a new car. The car is fast. The love is important in every relationship.* Learners identify which uses of *the* may be wrong. Write their ideas on the board without confirming them yet.
Presentation	20 min	Teach three rules. Rule 1: use *the* for specific reference (already mentioned, identified by context, or unique). Rule 2: no article for general categories (*Dogs are loyal pets.*). Rule 3: no article for abstract nouns used generally (*Honesty is important.*). Finish with a quick oral check: learners say *specific* or *general/abstract* for five sentences.
Activity 1: controlled practice	30 min	Worksheet of 10 sentences. Individual work (10 min), pair check (5 min), whole-class review (10 min) where learners explain the rule behind each answer. Allow time for transitions.
Activity 2: semi-controlled speaking	35 min	Groups of 3 or 4 receive three card types: abstract nouns, general categories, specific references. Give a debate question (*Should education be free for everyone? Does money bring happiness?*). Learners discuss using the cards and aim for 5 correct uses of no article and 5 correct uses of *the*. The teacher circulates and corrects.
Wrap-up	10 min	Review the rules and return to the lead-in sentences. Learners correct them.

Stage	Time	What happens
Homework	5 min	Write an 8 to 10 sentence paragraph: *What is more important for society, education or justice?* Use the zero article with abstract nouns and *the* for specific references.

Assessment

- Formative: oral understanding check, worksheet review, and teacher listening during the debate.
- Summative (homework): paragraph checked for correct article use.

Appendix A: Rule table

Article	Use for
the	Specific reference: already mentioned, identified by context, or unique
no article (zero)	General categories (*Dogs are loyal pets.*)
no article (zero)	Abstract nouns used generally (*Honesty is important.*)

References

Folse, K. S. (2016). *Keys to teaching grammar to English language learners* (2nd ed.). University of Michigan Press.

Ionin, T., Ko, H., & Wexler, K. (2004). Article semantics in second language acquisition: The role of specificity. *Language Acquisition, 12*(1), 3-69.